

4.4 Mobile Internet And Connectivity

Every new generation of technology challenges our worldview and paradigms. For example, a paradigm shift occurred when people moved from listening to the radio to watching TV. Another example is when people went from using standalone PCs to accessing the Internet on them. It's no surprise that mobility is causing yet another paradigm shift. However, it's important to realise that there is a difference between "being mobile" and "going wireless."

Mobile computing relates to the ability to interact with the device from anywhere, whereas wireless access defines the communication between computers or devices. In mobile phones, voice and text messaging has always been the primary mode of communication. Users can now also share graphics and pictures and even videos, but a normal mobile network has lower bandwidth, thus resulting in lower speeds of data transfer. To add to this, most mobile phones come with limited storage capacity.

The latest PDA models, however, provide an impressive amount of computing power in a small form factor. Also, their high-resolution graphics, handwriting recognition, point-and-click pen interface, and access to office productivity applications are useful tools. Potential learning applications include e-books, games, reference materials, and job aids.

A number of hybrid PDAs are available that combine additional hardware devices and functions, such as camera, cell phone, bar code reader, GPS receiver, and so forth. The increase in the use of high-end mobile phones (technologically advanced not necessarily expensive models) and PDAs has resulted in the widespread use of the Internet on these devices. With protocols designed to take care of the mobile Internet and special browsers designed for handhelds, navigating the mobile Internet has become easy.